West-Oak Stuns Top-Ranked Eastside on the Road

By Caleb James

For The Journal

TAYLORS — On a night that felt like February wrestling in early December, West-Oak walked into a packed Eastside High gym and left with the Warriors' grittiest statement of the young season. After slipping past fifth-ranked 5A opponent Greenwood in the night's opener, West-Oak saved its best for the main event, outlasting second-ranked Eastside, 39–39, and winning on the seventh criteria which goes to the team that has the greater number of first-points scored to close out a dramatic sweep on the night.

And from the very first whistle, the Warriors showed they weren't intimidated by the stage.

The dual opened at 215, where Ballard wasted no time setting an early tone. He attacked immediately, finishing off a decisive pin in 1:40, a jolt of momentum that West-Oak would need every bit of as the night unfolded.

"You know, our guys just kept fighting," head coach Derek Strobel said. "We got up, we got down, and we got back up. Against teams like this, you have to stay in it, and they did that tonight."

Eastside responded at heavyweight with a quick pin of its own, and the Eagles carried that momentum into the lower weights. Back-to-back first-period falls at 113 and 120 pushed Eastside in front and cracked open the gym's energy.

But West-Oak's middleweights have been reliable all season, and once again, they were the stabilizers.

At 126, Peyton Durham stopped the surge with a first-period pin. DeLaCruz followed with a 15–6 major decision at 132, and Rivera extended the roll with a dominant 19–3 tech fall at 138. What had been a tense stretch suddenly swung into one of the Warriors' most productive runs of the night, three straight matches that didn't just flip the scoreboard, but settled the team's composure.

At 144, Engram delivered the loudest moment of the middle-weight stretch, sticking his opponent in 1:08. West-Oak's bench rose to its feet, and for the first time in the dual, the Warriors looked like the team dictating the tempo.

Still, the Eagles pushed back. They secured a major at 150, a tech fall at 157, and later benefitted from a forfeit at 175, each point cutting into West-Oak's lead. A quick pin at 190 swung the lead back to Eastside, and suddenly the dual was wrapped in the kind of pressure both programs are built to handle.

And then the lineup cycled all the way back to where the night had started — right around the weight classes where West-Oak has made a living on toughness.

“Those pins are just a lot of hard work and dedication,” junior Sy Strobel said. “Getting those points for my team is very important for us. It means a lot.”

When the final heavyweight pin was called for Eastside, the gym froze with the scoreboard locked at 39–39. Six criteria came and went. The seventh broke the tie: first match points.

Advantage West-Oak.

“We wrestle Eastside every year for a reason,” Coach Strobel said. “We need to wrestle the best to see where we’re at, see what we need to work on. That’s the competition we want.”

For a team with postseason expectations, the night served its purpose. A two-point win over No. 5 Greenwood followed by a criteria win over No. 2 Eastside is sure to create a night that the Warriors of West-Oak will remember all season long.

“Just boosting our confidence and making us a better team overall,” Sy Strobel said. “All the work we’re putting in… winning matches like this makes us know we’re the best in the state.”

Two duals. Two ranked opponents. One long night in Taylors that showed exactly what West-Oak looks like when the lights turn on and it’s time to show who the best wrestlers in South Carolina are.

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West-Oak 37, Greenwood 35

106 — Porter (G) pinned Swelling, 1:22

113 — Zamora (G) pinned Blackwell, 0:56

120 — Ramirez (G) tech. fall Davis, 19-1

126 — Durham (W) pinned Molina, 1:45

132 — DeLaCruz (W) pinned Johnson, 0:54

138 — Rivera (W) maj. dec. Williams, 17-7

144 — Orvosh (W) dec. Porter, 5-0

150 — Howel (G) pinned hanks, 0:36

157 — Smith (W) dec. McFlroy, 9-5

165 — Strobel (W) pinned Garcia-Ramirez, 0:33

*175 — Saxon (W) dec. Moore, 14-7

190 — Ballard (W) pinned Hamilton, 0:15

215 — Cohen (G) pinned Doyle, 1:43

285 — Parks (G) pinned Whitfield, 4:38

* — Starting point of match

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West-Oak 39, Eastside 39

106 — Swilling (W) won by forfeit

113 — Prey (E) pinned Blackwell, 0:56

120 — Merret (E) pinned Davis, 1:33

126 — Durham (W) pinned Sloan, 1:46

132 — DeLacruz (W) maj. dec. Johnson, 15-6

138 — Rivera (W) tech. fall Salvato, 19-3

144 — Engram (W) pinned Ingle, 1:08

150 — Smouse (E) maj. dec. Orvosh, 9-1

157 — Wiley (E) tech. fall Driver, 15-0

165 — Strobel (W) pinned Schulz, 15-0

175 — Schrader (E) won by forfeit

190 — Lee (E) pinned Saxon, 1:02

* 215 — Ballard (W) pinned Stathakis, 1:40

285 — McGee (E) pinned Whitfield, 0:40

* — Starting point of match